

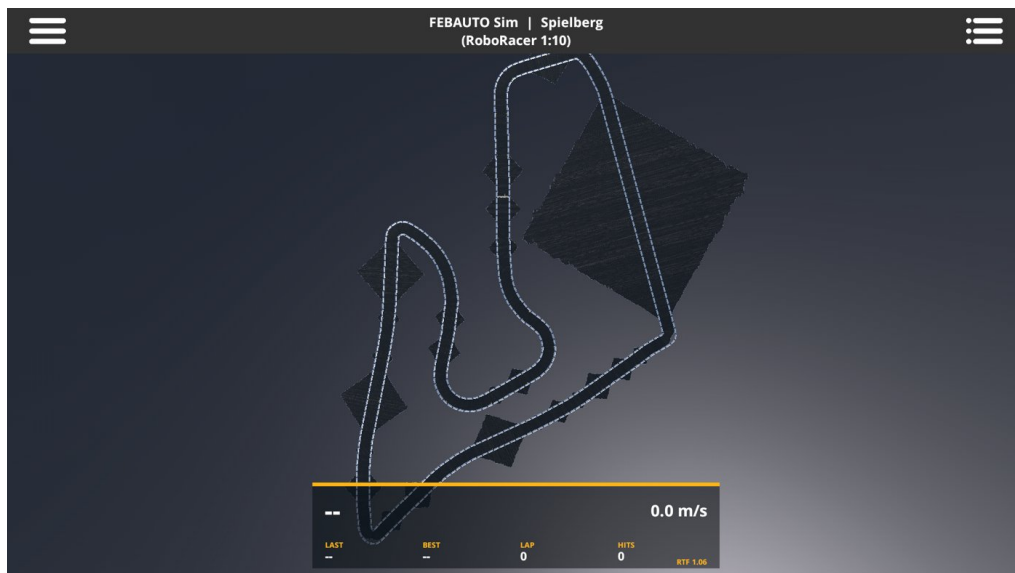


Autonomous Racing Hardware

Options, costs and benefits

Formula Electric at Berkeley, Autonomous Team

September 2026



The FEBAUTO simulator running the Red Bull Ring (Spielberg) at 1:10 scale.

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1 Executive summary

The autonomous team has built a complete software racing platform in the last month: a native simulator of the RoboRacer 1:10 race car, a containerised ROS 2 devkit, a starter driving stack, a competition harness, a leaderboard and two manuals. It onboards a new member in an hour and runs a full season (qualification, time-attack, head-to-head final) with no hardware. Its one limit is that the code never meets a real car.

This report lays out six options for closing that gap, from staying software-only to a 1:5-scale vehicle, with a full bill of materials for each, and recommends **Plan B: one RoboRacer-standard 1:10 car with a Hokuyo lidar and a lab track, about \$3,000**, with **Plan C, a second car, next semester**. Two options the committee asked about specifically, converting the team's Tamiya chassis and moving to a 1:4 or 1:5 scale car, are analysed in sections 4.5 and 4.6 and found not to be feasible for reasons of eligibility, community, track size and safety rather than cost. The depth camera the team already owns is assumed available and is not priced.

Plan	What	Cost (USD)	Verdict
0	Simulator only (status quo)	0	keep as the base of everything below
A	One 1:10 car, budget sensors and compute	1,400	viable; upgrade path to B
B	One 1:10 car, RoboRacer reference build	3,000	recommended
C	Two 1:10 cars (B + a budget second car)	4,400	recommended for the following semester
D	Convert the team's Tamiya 1:10 chassis	1,200	not feasible for competition; poor value
E	1:5-scale vehicle	6,500+	not feasible: track, safety, no community

Table 1: The options at a glance. All costs include compute, lidar, power, mounting and the lab track kit; prices are September 2026 list prices, rounded, to be verified at order time.

2 What exists today: the FEBAUTO simulator platform

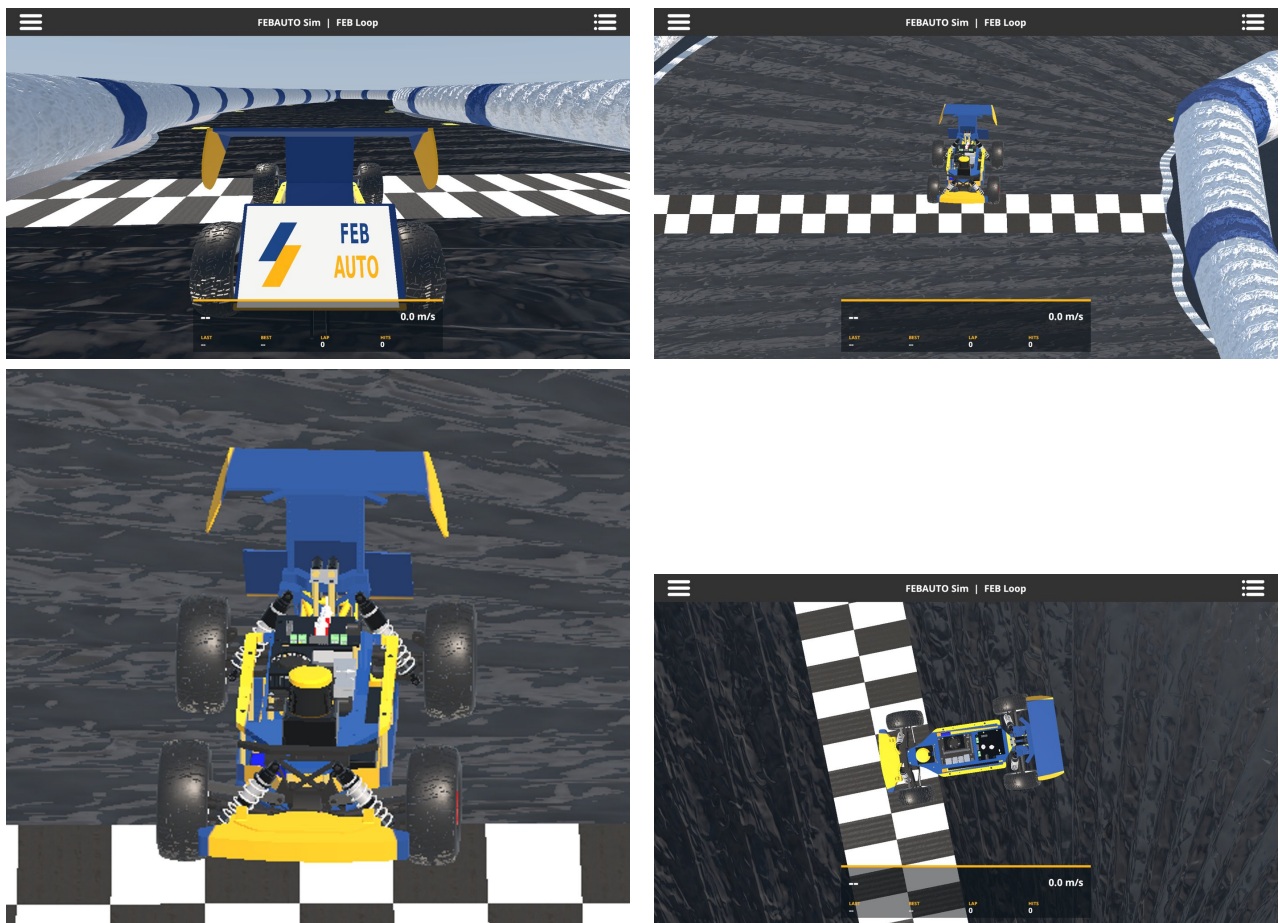


Figure 1: The RoboRacer car in the FEBAUTO simulator: chase view with the race HUD, front view, and two overhead views. The vehicle model is the league’s digital twin, unchanged; the livery and dressing are cosmetic.

2.1 The platform

Piece	What it does
Simulator	Native Mac, Windows and Linux app, a fork of the AutoDRIVE simulator. Tracks load from folders at run time (walls of 33 cm air duct, or FSAE-style cones). Up to four cars. Visual and bare looks. Race HUD, ghost lap, real-time factor readout.
Devkit	Docker image with ROS 2 Humble and the simulator bridge; the member’s code runs inside it; Foxglove for live visualisation on any laptop with nothing else installed.
Starter kit	A commented reactive driver that laps any track, tuning file, system-identification tool, and a learning path from tuning to mapping, racelines and model-predictive control.
House racer	A conservative opponent car for practising overtakes. Starts only when the member’s own stack starts.
Harness	Runs every submitted image on a secret track under league rules, records bags, audits banned topics, writes results, seeds and runs knockout brackets.
Site	Practice boards per track, qualification progress per team, event standings and brackets.
Manuals	Competitor manual (install to leaderboard entry) and organiser manual (tracks, events, race day, releases).

2.2 Tracks

Tracks are folders of a PNG and a YAML file, so a new one takes minutes and needs no rebuild. The team ships four: the FEB Loop, the same loop with FSAE cones instead of walls, the RoboRacer league's Porto practice track, and a custom circuit with a hairpin, esses and a chicane. Real circuits from the RoboRacer track database import directly: the Red Bull Ring at 1:10 scale, 342 m long, is shown on the cover and below.

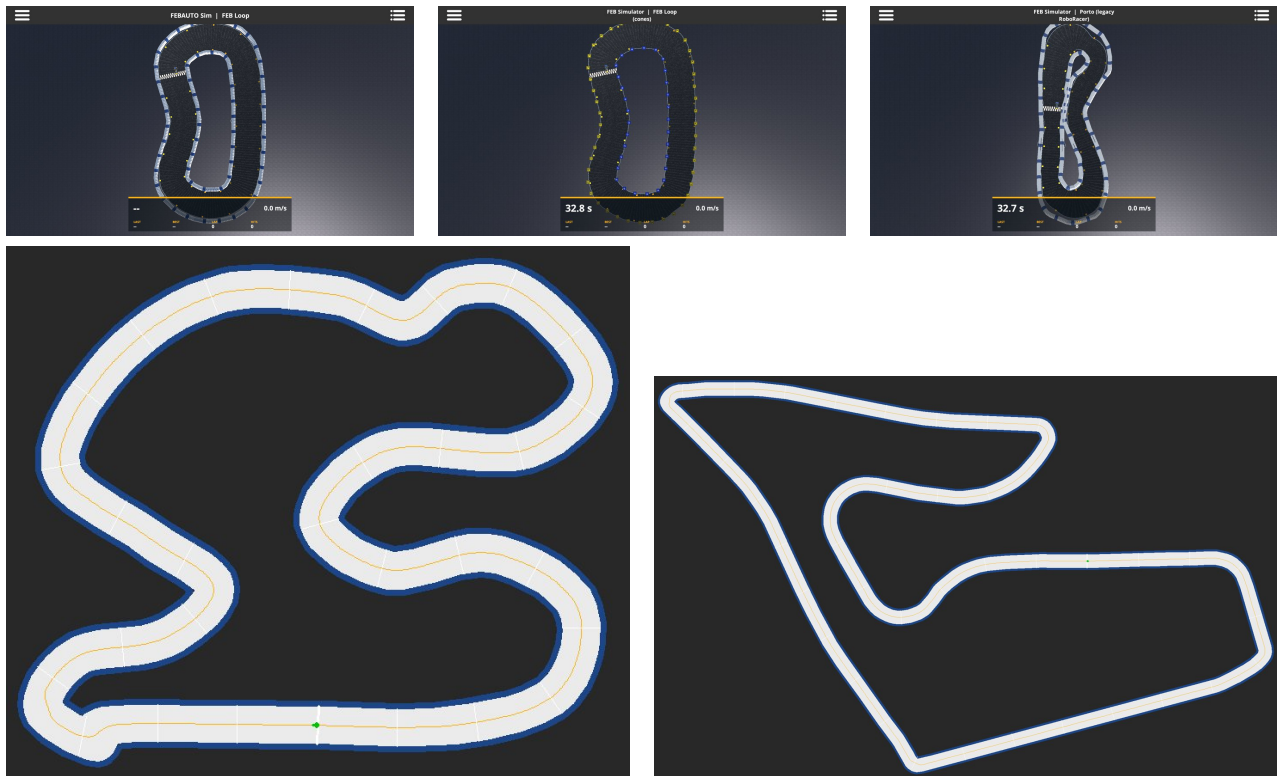


Figure 2: Top: the FEB Loop, its cone version, and Porto, in the simulator. Bottom: the generated maps of the custom FEB Circuit (138 m) and of Spielberg at 1:10 (342 m), with walls, centreline and checkpoints.

2.3 Onboarding and the season

A new member clones one repository, runs one setup command and drives manually. Copying the starter kit and running one more command puts an autonomous car on track; the first leaderboard entry follows the same afternoon. To qualify for the first competition a team completes ten laps with at most one collision on every practice track. Qualified teams race a time-attack on a secret track, and the top seeds meet in a two-car knockout final.

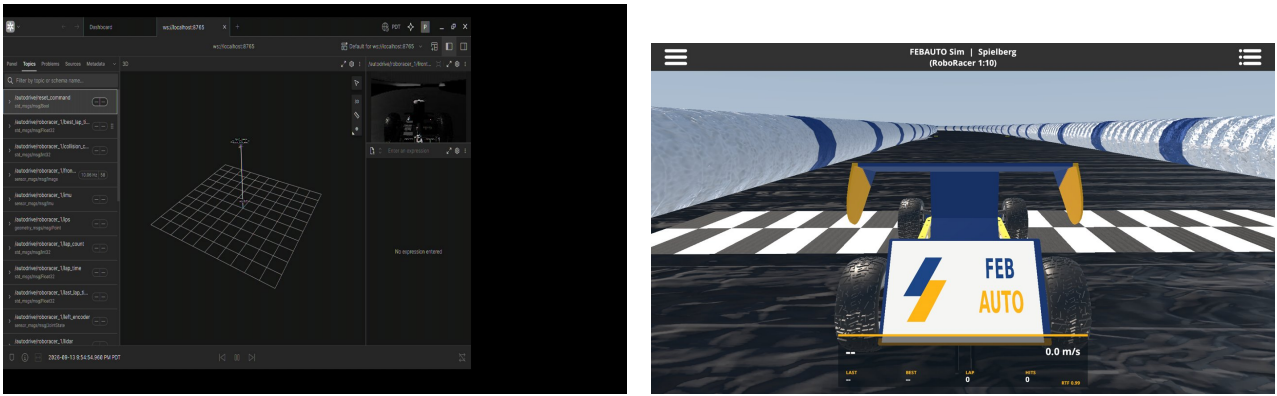


Figure 3: Left: Foxglove connected to the devkit, showing the car's topics and the front camera live. Right: the driver's view on Spielberg.

3 Why hardware, and why in the off-season

The FSAE car is not ready for autonomous work for most of the year: it is being designed, built, or raced by the rest of the team, and it is never available for an untested stack. A 1:10 car fills exactly that gap.

- **Sim-to-real is the point of the exercise.** The simulator's car is the digital twin of the RoboRacer reference vehicle. A stack tuned in the simulator is meant to transfer; without a car the claim is never tested, and members never meet real latency, tyre variation, a lidar that sees the room, or a battery that sags.
- **Off-season continuity.** Perception, localisation, planning and control are the same problems at 1:10 and at full scale. The 1:10 car is where the team develops and validates them between seasons, on a table in the lab, without waiting for the FSAE vehicle or a test day.
- **Driverless FSAE readiness.** Formula Student driverless events use cone tracks and camera plus lidar perception. The cone version of every FEBAUTO track exists for this reason; a real car with a camera and a 2D lidar lets the team practise that exact pipeline at small scale.
- **Competitions and recruiting.** RoboRacer runs physical races at ICRA, IROS and IFAC every year on the rules our league already uses. A car on a table is also what keeps a room full of new members after the first semester.
- **Cost of not doing it.** The software platform is done and free to run. Its value compounds only if what members build on it reaches hardware.

4 The options

Every plan includes compute, lidar, power, mounting and the track kit of section 5. Where a part is available in more than one grade, the table names the one priced.

4.1 Plan 0: simulator only

Cost \$0. Everything in section 2 continues. No sim-to-real work, no physical competition, no perception on real sensors. Kept as the base layer of every other plan, not as an answer on its own.

4.2 Plan A: one 1:10 car, budget grade

Item	USD	Note
Traxxas Slash 4x4 VXL (TRA68086)	500	the RoboRacer-eligible chassis; includes brushless motor and stock ESC
VESC-compatible controller, Flipsky mini (75100 or 6.7)	130	replaces the stock ESC; wheel odometry and IMU
Compute: Raspberry Pi 5, 8 GB, cooler, SD card	120	enough for lidar-only reactive driving and ROS 2
2D lidar: Slamtec RPLidar A2M12	320	12 m, 12 Hz, 0.25°; competition-legal
Two 3S 5000 mAh LiPo, charger, safety bag	190	
Power: buck converter, XT60 splitter, fuse	30	instead of the RoboRacer powerboard
Plates, standoffs, fasteners, USB hub, cables	90	plates laser-cut on campus from the published drawings
Spares: tyres, pinion, bumper	60	
Track kit (section 5)	240	
Total	1,680	about \$1,400 without the track kit

Benefits: the cheapest real car that runs the same ROS 2 stack as the simulator and is eligible for RoboRacer events. **Limits:** the Pi cannot run camera perception at useful rates and the lidar's 12 Hz and range noise cap safe speed at roughly 3 m/s. Both are upgrades, not rebuilds: swap the compute and lidar and Plan A becomes Plan B.

4.3 Plan B: one 1:10 car, RoboRacer reference build (recommended)

Item	USD	Note
Traxxas Slash 4x4 VXL (TRA68086)	500	chassis with brushless motor
VESC 6 MkVI	260	the reference controller
Compute: NVIDIA Jetson Orin Nano developer kit	250	camera perception and learning-based stacks
2D lidar: Hokuyo UST-10LX	1,500	the reference sensor; 40 Hz, 270°, 10 m, the same as the simulator's
Two 3S 5000 mAh LiPo, charger, safety bag	190	
RoboRacer powerboard	100	clean rails for Jetson, lidar and VESC; safe shut-down
Plates, standoffs, fasteners, USB hub, cables	90	
Spares: tyres, pinion, bumper	60	
Depth camera	0	the team's Intel RealSense, already owned
Track kit (section 5)	240	
Total	3,190	about \$2,950 without the track kit

Benefits: the exact car the league, the build guide and our simulator model; camera plus lidar fusion is possible on day one; nothing to upgrade later. **Limits:** the lidar is half the cost and the most fragile part; a bumper and a speed limit for new stacks are part of the plan.

4.4 Plan C: two cars

Plan B plus a second car built to Plan A's grade (\$1,400, no second track kit): total about \$4,600, or \$4,400 if the second car reuses the first car's charger and spares. **Benefits:** the head-to-head final on real cars, a spare during a competition, and two members' stacks testable at once. The budget car is the natural second car because racecraft, not sensor grade, is what head-to-head tests. Recommended for the semester after Plan B.

4.5 Plan D: convert the team's Tamiya 1:10 chassis

The team owns a motorless Tamiya touring-car chassis. Priced as a full conversion:

Item	USD	Note
Tamiya chassis	0	owned
Brushless motor and ESC or VESC, steering servo	200	the kit has neither
Compute, lidar, power, cables as Plan A	760	
Custom sensor deck and mounts (design, prints, iterations)	80	no published drawings exist for this chassis
Track kit	240	
Total	1,280	saves about \$400 against Plan A

Why it is not feasible as the team's car:

- **Not competition-eligible.** RoboRacer rules require a Traxxas 1:10 chassis (codes TRA74054, TRA6804R, TRA68086). A Tamiya cannot enter any physical event.
- **Not the simulated car.** Wheelbase, track width, tyre model and steering geometry differ from the digital twin, so simulator tuning does not transfer, which removes the main reason to have a car.
- **No community.** Every RoboRacer document, drawing, VESC profile and forum answer assumes the Slash. On the Tamiya the team solves mounting, power and drivetrain questions alone. That is a semester of mechanical work that teaches no autonomy.
- **Weak platform.** A touring car has 5 mm of ground clearance and no room for a lidar, a computer and a battery. The Slash was chosen by the community because it carries them.

The chassis is still useful as a bench mule for wiring and sensor mounting practice, at no cost.

4.6 Plan E: a 1:5-scale vehicle

The committee asked about a 1:4 car. No manufacturer makes a 1:4 road car; the nearest production platforms are 1:5 short-course trucks (Losi 5IVE-T, Arrma Kraton 8S) and 1:6 monster trucks (Traxxas X-Maxx). Priced with the same sensors and compute as Plan B:

Item	USD	Note
1:5 electric chassis (8S class)	1,300 to 1,900	8 to 12 kg, 50 km/h and up
8S battery pair and charger	500	
High-current controller (VESC 75V/300A class)	350	
Compute, lidar, camera mount as Plan B	1,850	
Custom deck, roll protection, kill switch	400	nothing published to copy
Track: outdoor-sized (see below)	2,000+	
Total	6,400 to 7,000	

Why it is not feasible:

- **Track size.** A corridor for a 1:5 car is at least 3 m wide and a lap needs 150 m or more: a parking lot, not a lab. Air-duct walls do not work at that scale; the walls become barriers and the track cannot be stored.
- **Safety.** A 10 kg vehicle at 50 km/h carries about 1 kJ of kinetic energy, thirty times a 1:10 car. It cannot be run indoors, near people, or by a first-semester member's untested stack. It needs a kill switch, roll protection and a marshal.
- **No community and no competition.** No autonomous racing series exists at that scale. Every problem, from mounts to motor control, is solved alone.
- **Not the simulated car.** Nothing built in the simulator transfers.
- **Cost.** Twice Plan B before the track, and the track is a separate project.

5 The track kit

Item	USD	Note
Flexible aluminium duct, 12–13 inch (33 cm) diameter, 4 lengths of 25 ft (about 30 m total)	130	the league's walls; folds flat to store; joins with tape
FSAE-style cones, 3D-printed at 1:10 (100 pieces)	15	32 mm tall, blue and yellow filament, about 10 g each; printed on the team's printers
Floor tape, start-line gate (photo interrupter), storage tub	95	
Total	240	

Thirty metres of duct builds a 12 m by 6 m loop with a hairpin, the same geometry as the FEB Loop in the simulator. The cones give the cone version of the same track for camera work, and scale exactly like the simulator's cone tracks.

6 Sensor fusion and the driverless connection

The team already owns an Intel RealSense depth camera. With a 2D lidar it gives the sensor pair used by Formula Student driverless cars at small scale: the camera classifies cones by colour and the lidar gives precise range and bearing; fusing them yields a cone map, then a track boundary, then a raceline. The FEBAUTO simulator publishes both a front camera image and a lidar scan on the

same topics the real car will use, and its cone tracks exist for exactly this pipeline. Plans B and C support this on day one; Plan A's compute is enough for lidar-only driving and can be upgraded to a Jetson for camera work later.

7 Racing: one on one

The head-to-head final is the season's finish. In the simulator two cars race on one track, each team's stack in its own container, contact costs both cars a penalty and a respawn, and the finishing order is laps then time. The figures below are a race on Spielberg between the starter kit and the house racer.

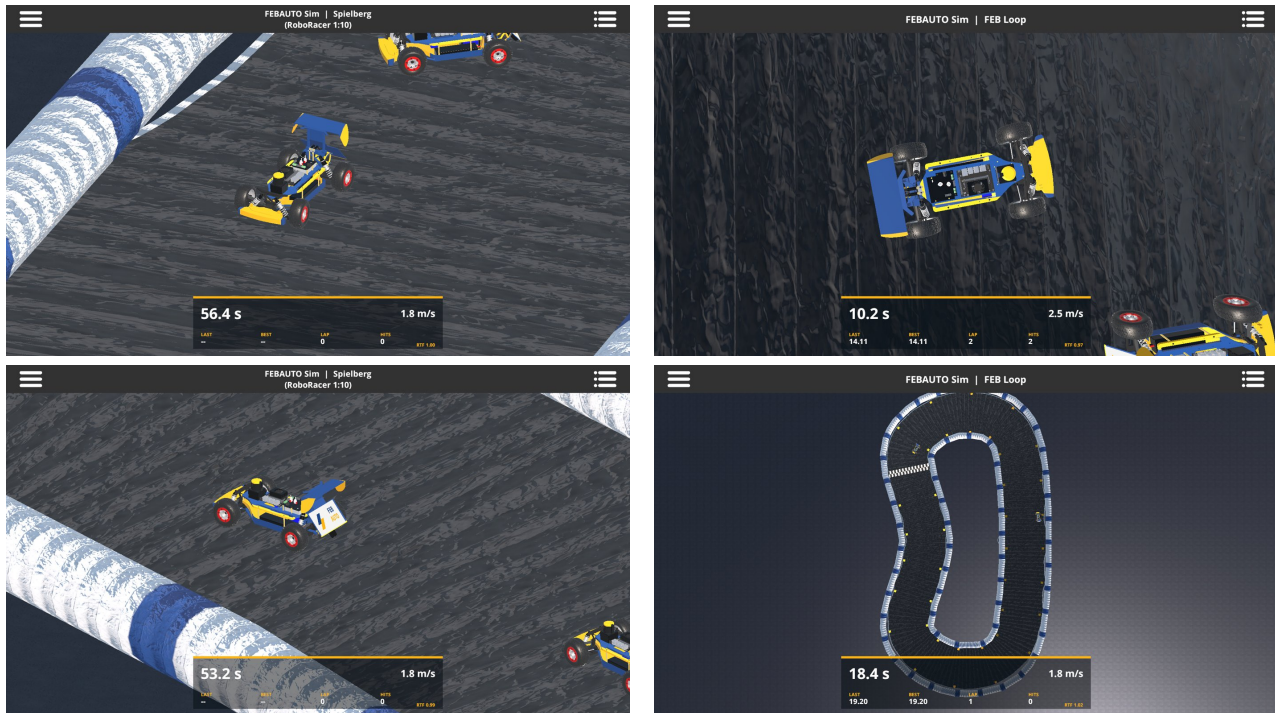


Figure 4: One-on-one AI racing. Top: on Spielberg, the house racer (top of frame, left) closing on the member's car, and a moment earlier as it enters the frame (right). Bottom: on the FEB Loop, both cars in the same corner from above (left) and the whole track with both cars (right). Each car runs an unchanged competitor image behind the harness proxy; contact costs both cars a penalty and a respawn.

With Plan C the same race runs on two real cars on the lab track.

8 Recommendation and timeline

Fund Plan B now (\$3,190 plus 10% contingency, \$3,500) and Plan C's second car next semester (\$1,400). Order the lidar first; its lead time is the longest.

When	Milestone
Order + 2 weeks	Car assembled from the RoboRacer build guide; manual drive; sensors on ROS 2; track laid
+ 4 weeks	Starter kit laps the lab track; simulator-to-car gap measured and written up
+ 8 weeks	Qualified teams run their stacks on the car; first internal physical time-attack
Following semester	Second car; head-to-head on hardware; entry to a RoboRacer physical event

9 Risks

- **Crashes.** Bumper, soft duct walls, a speed limit for new stacks; spares budgeted. The lidar is the fragile part and sits behind the bumper line.
- **Batteries.** LiPo bag, supervised charging, a written procedure before the first charge.
- **Supply.** Hokuyo lead times vary; every other part is stocked by hobby and electronics retailers.
- **Access.** The car lives with the autonomous lead; access follows the simulator's qualification rule, so an untested stack never has the car as its first target.

Platform: <https://github.com/Pranman1/feb-racing> Leaderboard: <https://pranman1.github.io/feb-racing/>

RoboRacer build guide and bill of materials: <https://f1tenth.readthedocs.io>

RoboRacer rules: https://github.com/f1tenth/roboracer_rules Track database: https://github.com/f1tenth/f1tenth_racetracks